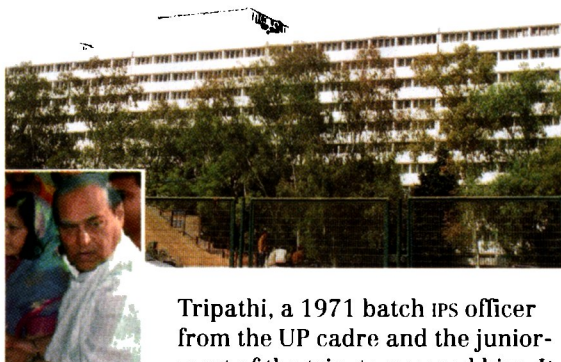


DELHI | RAW Appeal

Its credibility may be at its lowest in over four decades but the cloak and dagger succession struggle for the next chief of India's external intelligence service the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) has begun. Ashok Chaturvedi, arguably its most controversial head, retires on January 31 next year and there are three hats from diverse backgrounds in the ring. The seniormost is P. Vijay Kumar, a 1971-batch Research Analysis Service cadre officer and a 'Kaoboy' selected by the legendary R.N. Kao and second in line is Rana Banerjee, a 1971 batch Assam cadre IAS officer. Chaturvedi is said to be gunning for a gubernatorial appointment even as he backs his protégé, Sanjiv

R&AW HQ AND CHATURVEDI (BELOW LEFT)



Tripathi, a 1971 batch IPS officer from the UP cadre and the junior-most of the trio, to succeed him. It remains to be seen which of the three lobbies in the R&AW finally prevails.

by Sandeep Unnithan

KOLKATA | Subprime Preacher

Nilotpal Basu should stop being so self-righteous. GRASSO, an NGO he runs, has defaulted on a Rs 4-crore loan taken from the Union Bank of India and now wants the bank to settle on a "one-time payment of Rs 50 lakh". Another rural banking project that GRASSO started with ICICI bank has also gone under. Basu distances himself from GRASSO's woes saying, "I am just a chairman. The operations are being done by the executives."

All for Change

The decision to build new NSG hubs and buy sophisticated arms for commandos has earned Home Minister P. Chidambaram much praise. But it was Chidambaram the finance minister who cited financial constraints to veto similar proposals made by his predecessor.

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